

Word family: **city / cities / citywide / inner-city**

Base word: city

Plural: cities

Useful related forms / compounds: citywide, inner-city

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / compound-related forms (相關複合詞)

Your sentence:

> “For example, he once spent fifteen minutes explaining why old tram routes can tell you more about a **city** than a history textbook.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **city** means a **large and important urban area where many people live and work, with its buildings, transport, institutions, history, and social life considered together**.

繁體中文： **人口較多、建築和交通密集，並具有完整社會、經濟和公共設施的城市地區**

中文翻譯：

> “...old tram routes can tell you more about a **city** than a history textbook.”

「.....舊電車路線比歷史教科書更能告訴你一座**城市**的故事。」

Here:

city = 由人口、街道、建築、交通、社區和公共機構共同構成的城市

1. **city** = large urban place (城市本身) — 城市；都市

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: A large, developed urban area where many people live and work.

Practice 1 — Original

> “Old tram routes can tell you more about a **city** than a history textbook.”

「舊電車路線比歷史教科書更能告訴你一座**城市**的故事。」

Practice 2

> “The **city** has changed dramatically over the past twenty years.”

「這座**城市**在過去二十年間有很大的變化。」

Practice 3

> “She prefers living in a busy **city**.”

「她比較喜歡住在繁忙的**城市**。」

****city** = 人口集中、建築和道路密集，而且具有完整公共及商業設施的大型都市地區**

Common:

- * city centre
- * city streets
- * city transport
- * city life
- * city population

These belong to one physical/urban-place sense.

2. ****the city** = city government / municipal authority (市政府 / 市政當局) — 市政府；市政當局

****City** can also refer metonymically to the government or public authority responsible for the city.

Practice 4

> “The **city** plans to build a new public library.”

「****市政府**計劃興建一座新的公共圖書館。」

Practice 5

> “The **city** has introduced new parking regulations.”

「****市政當局**推出了新的泊車規例。」

****the city** = 負責管理該城市公共服務、規劃及行政事務的市政府或市政機構**

This is genuinely different from the physical place itself.

Compare:

> “The city is crowded.”

= 城市本身很擁擠。

> “The city approved the project.”

= 市政府批准了這個項目。

3. **city = people/community of a city collectively (城市居民) — 全市居民；城市社群**

Sometimes **city** represents the people who live in it.

Practice 6

> “The whole **city** celebrated the victory.”

「**全市居民**都在慶祝這場勝利。」

Practice 7

> “The tragedy shocked the entire **city**.”

「這宗悲劇令**全市的人**都感到震驚。」

city = 以整座城市作為整體來指生活在其中的居民和社群

This is another metonymic use:

> place → people living there

For database purposes, I would keep this explicit because the referent has shifted from a physical urban area to **its population**.

4. **city = official/legal municipality (行政區 / 市) — 市；城市行政單位**

In government or administrative contexts, **city** can mean a formally recognized municipal area or jurisdiction.

Practice 8

> “The property lies just outside the **city** limits.”

「這個物業位於**市界**以外不遠。」

Practice 9

> “The **city** covers an area of more than 300 square kilometres.”

「這個**市級行政區**面積超過三百平方公里。」

city = 依法或行政上劃定、由市政府管轄的城市行政範圍

This overlaps with the physical-place sense but focuses on:

> **official boundaries and jurisdiction**

rather than the built-up urban area.

For core counting, I would likely merge it with Meaning 1 unless administrative distinctions are especially important for your learner set.

5. **the City = financial/business district or institutionally defined central district (特定城市中心區) — 金融區 / 市中心區**

In some established place names and contexts, **the City** can refer to a specific central business or historical district.

The best-known example is:

> **the City of London / the City**

meaning London's historic financial district.

Practice 10

> “He works in the **City**.”

「他在倫敦金融城 / **倫敦市金融區**工作。」

Practice 11

> “Many financial firms are based in the **City**.”

「很多金融公司都設於**倫敦金融城**。」

This is a proper-name or specialized geographical use rather than a broad general meaning of

lowercase **city**.

So I would treat it as a **specialized extension**, not a core learner sense unless relevant.

Related form: **citywide**

Citywide means across the whole city.

Practice 12

> “The new policy will apply **citywide**.”

「新政策將在**全市範圍內**實施。」

Practice 13

> “There was a **citywide** transport strike.”

「當時發生了一場**全市性的**交通罷工。」

citywide = 涉及、影響或遍及整座城市的

Related form: **inner-city**

Inner-city usually refers to older, densely populated central urban areas, often discussed in social or economic contexts.

Practice 14

> “The programme supports **inner-city** schools.”

「這個計劃支援**市中心舊城區 / 內城區**的學校。」

Practice 15

> “Housing costs have changed many **inner-city** neighbourhoods.”

「房屋成本改變了很多**內城區**社區。」

inner-city = 位於大型城市較中心、人口通常較密集的舊有城市地區

This is a useful compound, not another meaning of bare **city**.

Important distinction: **city vs town**

city

usually refers to a larger or more officially significant urban area.

town

usually refers to a smaller urban settlement.

However, the exact legal distinction varies by country.

So for learners:

city = generally larger urban centre

town = generally smaller urban settlement

The distinction is not purely based on population worldwide.

Important distinction: **city vs urban area**

city

can refer to:

- * the built-up place,
- * the municipality,
- * its government,
- * its people.

urban area

is a more technical geographical term focusing on continuously built-up settlement.

A city's administrative boundary may extend beyond its dense urban area.

Important distinction: **city vs countryside**

city

= densely built urban environment

countryside

= rural areas outside towns and cities

> city life

> countryside life

This is a broad urban-rural contrast.

Important distinction: **city vs capital**

city

is any city.

capital

is a city serving as the main seat of government for a country, region, etc.

So:

> every capital is a city in ordinary usage

but:

> not every city is a capital.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family is relatively small:

* **city**

* **cities**

* **citywide**

* **inner-city**

Useful compounds include:

- * city centre
- * city hall
- * city council
- * city limits
- * city life
- * city streets

These generally retain the same core urban-place concept and should not be counted as additional meanings merely because the following noun changes. The Golden Manual says useful compounds should be included when educationally valuable while avoiding artificial semantic splitting.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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city — urban place	人口集中、建築及道路密集，並具有完整公共、商業和社會設施的大型城市地區
the city — municipal government	負責管理該城市公共服務、規劃及行政事務的市政府或市政機構
city — inhabitants collectively	以整座城市作為整體來指生活在其中的居民和城市社群
city — administrative municipality	依法或行政上劃定、由市政府管轄的城市行政範圍；與一般城市義高度相關
the City — specialized proper-name use	在特定語境中指某座城市的歷史 / 金融核心區，例如倫敦金融城
citywide	涉及、影響或遍及整座城市的
inner-city	位於大型城市較中心、人口密集的舊有城市地區

For your original sentence

> “...old tram routes can tell you more about a **city** than a history textbook.”

The exact meaning is:

city = 由街道、建築、交通、居民、社區和公共機構共同構成的城市

So:

> **tell you more about a city**

= **讓你更了解一座城市本身的發展、生活方式和結構**

For your database, I would count **3 genuinely useful core meanings** for **city**:

1. ****the urban place itself****
2. ****the municipal government/authority****
3. ****the inhabitants/community collectively****

I would merge the ****administrative municipality**** use into #1 unless legal/geographical precision is needed, and treat ****the City****, ****citywide****, and ****inner-city**** as specialized or compound extensions rather than inflate the core count.